CLICK, DISCARD, FORGET: TECHNOLOGY BECOMES SILENT

POISON IN MALAYSIA

BY: YUNA NAZWA

Discarded electronic waste, including computers and smartphones, at a landfill in Malaysia. (Source: Google Images)

E-Waste: A Toxic Legacy of Innovation

In the eyes of the world, Malaysia is a shining example of digital progress. With the widespread internet access, 5G implementation and the increase of economical power with the help of innovation, it's easy to assume that the country's technological journey is a success story. Yet, beneath the polished surface of our digital lifestyle lies a quiet but growing electronic waste, or e-waste, that is piling up faster than we can control.

Each year, Malaysians discard more than 1.1 million tonnes of e-waste, which is a staggering amount equivalent to 110,000 full shipping containers. That's nearly one container for every 300 people in the country. But here's the catch: only 15% of that waste is recycled through legal and safe channels. The remainder ends up in rivers, abandoned fields, illegal landfills and incinerators.

This isn't just an environmental issue but a health time bomb. Electronic waste is loaded with hazardous materials, such as lead, cadmium, mercury, arsenic and brominated flame retardants that do not break down in nature. These toxic substances leach into our soil, flow into our rivers, rise into the air and eventually enter our bodies. In our race for digital modernity, have we unknowingly traded convenience for contamination?

Discarded electronic waste, including computers and smartphones, at a landfill in Malaysia. (Source: Google Images)

The Alarming Reality on the Ground

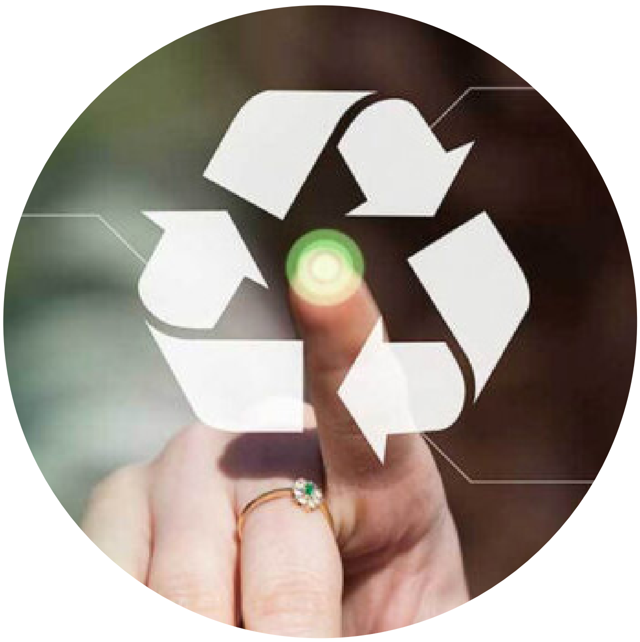
If numbers alone aren't convincing, just look at the field reports. A study by the National Hydraulic Research Institute of Malaysia (NAHRIM) found that 72% of major rivers in the Klang Valley have been contaminated with lead and cadmium, largely traced back to improperly discarded circuit boards, batteries and electronic components.

In Penang's industrial zones, groundwater samples reveal the presence of mercury, a dangerous neurotoxin which is 3.2 times above safe limits. Mercury doesn't just vanish, but it builds up in fish, in crops and eventually in the human body. This substance can damage the brain, kidneys and nervous system.

Step outside Kuala Lumpur to a place like Kundang and the picture gets even more real. Black smoke rises day and night from an illegal dumpsite that locals say has been operating unchecked for years. Siti is a mother of three who lives just 500 metres away from the site and has said that the doctors told her that her son's asthma is caused by air pollution, but no one investigates where it's coming from.

Kundang isn't an isolated case. In 2024 alone, the Department of Environment (DOE) identified 47 illegal e-waste dumpsites across Malaysia. These sites operate in the shadows, out of sight from the public, but dangerously close to where people live, work and raise children.

Environmental damage caused by e-waste is not a distant threat but it is already happening right now, in our backyards.



Discarded electronic waste, including computers and smartphones, at a landfill in Malaysia. (Source: Google Images)

Convenience to Waste

Why does Malaysia, a country of about
33 million peoplegenerate such a massive volume of electronic waste?

Discarded electronic waste, including computers and smartphones, at a landfill in Malaysia. (Source: Google Images)

The answer lies in our obsession with technology upgrades. According to the Malaysian Communications and Multimedia Commission (MCMC), Malaysia's smartphone penetration rate is a whopping 130%, meaning we own more phones than people. But the concerning part is that we only keep our devices for about 18 months on average.

Why? Because we're constantly bombarded by advertisements urging us to "upgrade", "replace", and "buy the latest". New models are released every six months. Flash sales and influencer promotions create artificial urgency. Social media fuels a cycle of comparison, where owning the newest gadget becomes a status symbol. Even perfectly functional devices are cast aside, simply because something "better" is out.

While there are 32 licensed e-waste recycling facilities in Malaysia, many are underutilised. Urban communities have easier access, but rural Malaysians, such as villagers in Sarawak, must travel up to 100 km just to reach a recycling point. Faced with such inconvenience, many turn to unlicensed collectors who promise "easy disposal" but often end up illegally exporting the waste or dumping it in an out-of-sight location. The result? A system that rewards speed and convenience but punishes the environment.

Power Through Innovation

Still, all hope is not lost. Recognising the scale of the problem, Malaysia has introduced the National E-Waste Management Plan 2023–2030, which mandates Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR). This policy holds electronics manufacturers accountable for the entire lifecycle of their products.

Tech giants like Sony, Samsung and Panasonic must now establish state-level e-waste collection hubs or face penalties of up to RM200,000. Meanwhile, companies that recycle more than 50% of their products receive tax incentives, encouraging corporate responsibility through financial rewards. At the grassroots level, movements like KitarSemulaMY are reshaping public habits.

This initiative, launched by eco-entrepreneur Arif Johari, uses a simple app that lets Malaysians schedule e-waste pickups from their homes. "We make responsible disposal as easy as online shopping," says Arif. So far, the project has reached 40,000 households and collected 78 tonnes of e-waste, a modest but meaningful start. Private industry is also stepping up.

In Negeri Sembilan, a state-of-the-art recycling plant operated by Cenviro can process 80,000 tonnes annually. With metal-separating robots and a closed-loop water treatment system, it can safely recover up to 95% of hazardous materials, proving that sustainable e-waste management is not only possible but profitable.

Discarded electronic waste, including computers and smartphones, at a landfill in Malaysia. (Source: Google Images)

Discarded electronic waste, including computers and smartphones, at a landfill in Malaysia. (Source: Google Images)

Technology itself is not the problem; it's how we treat it and how we try to overcome this issue. In a secondary school in Johor Bahru, teacher Aiman leads a student project called "Repair, Don't Replace". Instead of throwing away broken phones and tablets, students learn how to troubleshoot, repair, and restore them. In one year alone, his students managed to fix 120 mobile phones. "Teenagers who fix their devices begin to understand their value," says Aiman. "They stop seeing electronics as disposable toys."

Environmental experts agree. Associate Professor Dr Subramaniam from Universiti Putra Malaysia (UPM) notes, "Every additional year you use a smartphone reduces its carbon footprint by 31%." In other words, repairing a device is not just frugal, but it's a meaningful act of environmental preservation. Education, when combined with accessibility, can be powerful. Schools, workplaces, and communities should make recycling as natural as taking out the trash. When people are aware of the consequences, they are more likely to act responsibly.

Discarded electronic waste, including computers and smartphones, at a landfill in Malaysia. (Source: Google Images)

Discarded electronic waste, including computers and smartphones, at a landfill in Malaysia. (Source: Google Images)

SMART GADGETS

We live in an age where technology is deeply woven into every layer of our lives. From smartphones to smart homes, from laptops to wearable devices, we rely on machines to stay connected, informed and entertained. We use them to work, to learn to communicate and even to relax. Technology has become so embedded in our daily routines that many of us cannot imagine a single day without it.

THE AFTERLIFE

Yet beneath the excitement of each new model lies a truth that many prefer to ignore. Every time we unbox the latest gadget, we begin a silent countdown to its eventual disposal. The question we rarely ask is not 'What can this device do for us?' but 'What will happen to it when we are done?' The reality is that electronic devices do not simply disappear once they are discarded. They linger. They leach. They pollute.

OUR NEGLECT

It is not technology itself that harms us. The poison lies in our neglect in the way we treat our devices as disposable in how quickly we move from one to the next without thinking about the consequences. When we choose convenience over responsibility, we shift the burden to the environment, to future generations and to the health of communities that live near our growing piles of e-waste.

CROSSROADS

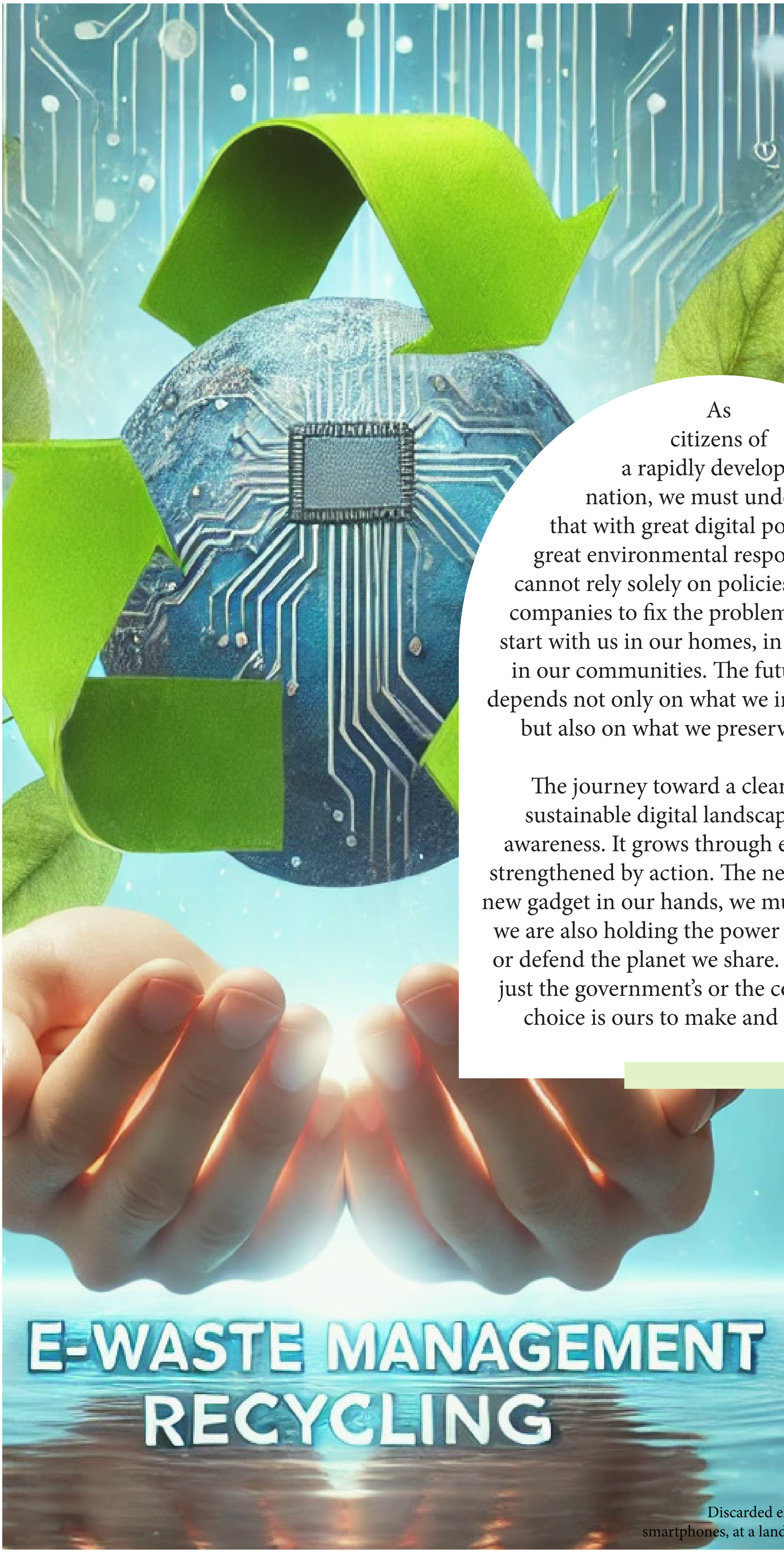
Malaysia stands at a crossroads. On one side is a future driven by innovation, where digital growth continues to bring opportunity. On the other side is the mounting cost of that progress measured in toxic rivers, polluted soil and damaged health. If we continue to ignore the rising tide of e-waste, we risk allowing this silent poison to undo the very benefits that technology promised us in the first place.

SIMPLE ACTIONS

The solution is not complex, but it requires will. We must repair instead of replace. We must recycle instead of discarding. We must educate instead of ignoring. Every action, no matter how small, contributes to a greater impact. When one person chooses to recycle a phone, it may seem insignificant. But when thousands or millions make the same choice, it becomes a movement.

GRAIN BY GRAIN

There is wisdom in the Malay saying Grain by grain, a mountain is formed. It teaches us that meaningful change does not happen overnight. It happens through repeated actions, through persistent awareness and through the commitment of individuals who believe in doing what is right. A phone that is fixed, a laptop that is reused, or a battery that is disposed of properly is more than just an item kept out of the landfill. It is a statement. It says I care about the future. It says I understand that my choices matter.



As citizens of a rapidly developing nation, we must understand that with great digital power comes great environmental responsibility. We cannot rely solely on policies and recycling companies to fix the problem. Change must start with us in our homes, in our schools and in our communities. The future of Malaysia depends not only on what we invent or purchase but also on what we preserve and protect.

The journey toward a cleaner and more sustainable digital landscape begins with awareness. It grows through education and is strengthened by action. The next time we hold a new gadget in our hands, we must remember that we are also holding the power to either damage or defend the planet we share. The choice is not just the government's or the corporations'. The choice is ours to make and it begins now.

Discarded electronic waste, including computers and smartphones, at a landfill in Malaysia. (Source: Google Images)